

forgotten some of the details. You can always study your code for a while and figure out how segments were supposed to work, but writing good comments can save you time by summarizing your overall approach clearly.

If you want to become a professional programmer or collaborate with other programmers, you should write meaningful comments. Today, most software is written collaboratively, whether by a group of employees at one company or a group of people working together on an open source project. Skilled programmers expect to see comments in code, so it's best to start adding descriptive comments to your programs now. Writing clear, concise comments in your code is one of the most beneficial habits you can form as a new programmer.

When you're deciding whether to write a comment, ask yourself if you had to consider several approaches before coming up with a reasonable way to make something work; if so, write a comment about your solution. It's much easier to delete extra comments later than to go back and write comments for a sparsely commented program. From now on, I'll use comments in examples throughout this book to help explain sections of code.

TRY IT YOURSELF

2-11. Adding Comments: Choose two of the programs you've written, and add at least one comment to each. If you don't have anything specific to write because your programs are too simple at this point, just add your name and the current date at the top of each program file. Then write one sentence describing what the program does.

The Zen of Python

Experienced Python programmers will encourage you to avoid complexity and aim for simplicity whenever possible. The Python community's philosophy is contained in "The Zen of Python" by Tim Peters. You can access this brief set of principles for writing good Python code by entering `import this` into your interpreter. I won't reproduce the entire "Zen of Python" here, but I'll share a few lines to help you understand why they should be important to you as a beginning Python programmer.

```
>>> import this
The Zen of Python, by Tim Peters
Beautiful is better than ugly.
```

Python programmers embrace the notion that code can be beautiful and elegant. In programming, people solve problems. Programmers have always respected well-designed, efficient, and even beautiful solutions to problems. As you learn more about Python and use it to write more code,